

How to Become a Top Performing IAM Leader

Rebecca Archambault

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IAM Leaders Need to Be ...

Conductors

Performers

Composers

... driving both security and business outcomes



① “Unasking”

Source: [Maverick Research: Embed the Power of Unasking in Your Team](#)

Key Issues



**Building trust for
people, process
and technology**



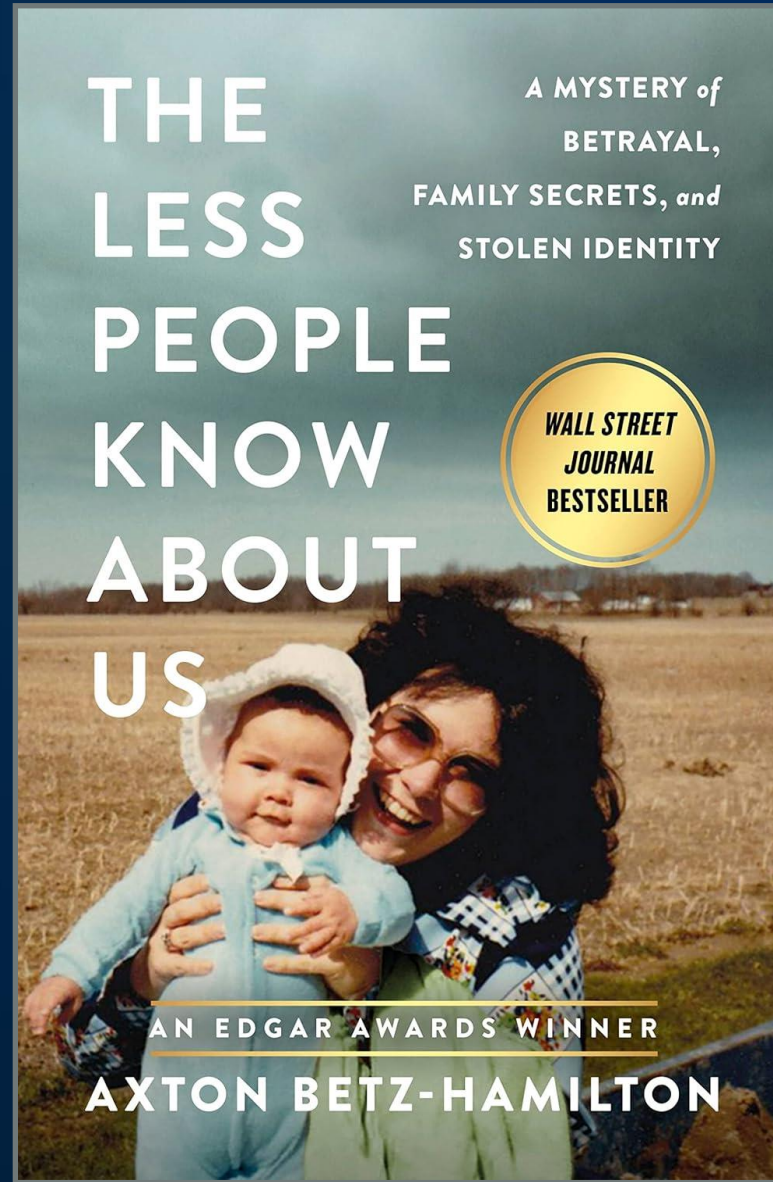
The power
of “unasking”



Four steps to
become a great
IAM leader

**“Trust is like the air we breathe.
When it’s present, nobody really notices;
when it’s absent, everybody notices.”**

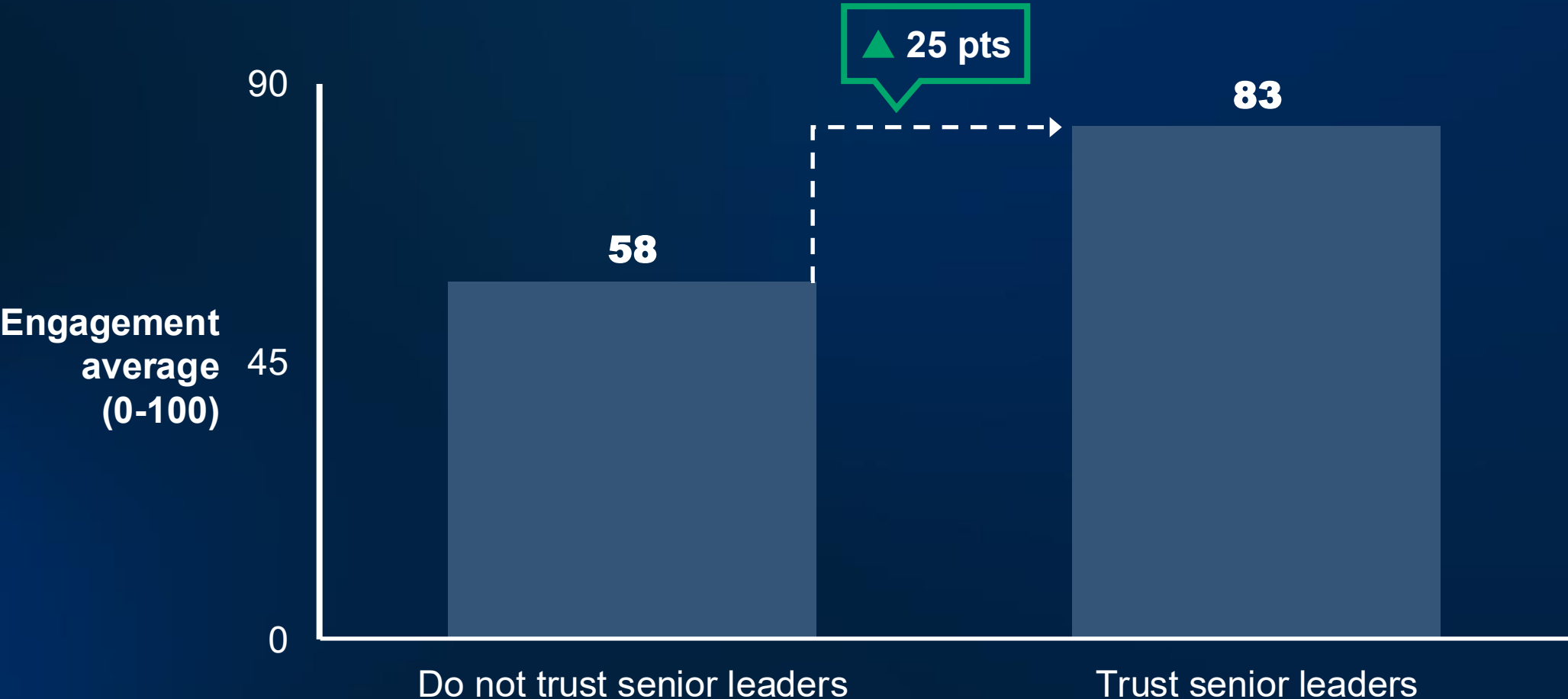
— Warren Buffett



Source: A. Betz-Hamilton, "The Less People Know About Us: A Mystery of Betrayal, Family Secrets, and Stolen Identity," Grand Central Publishing, 2019

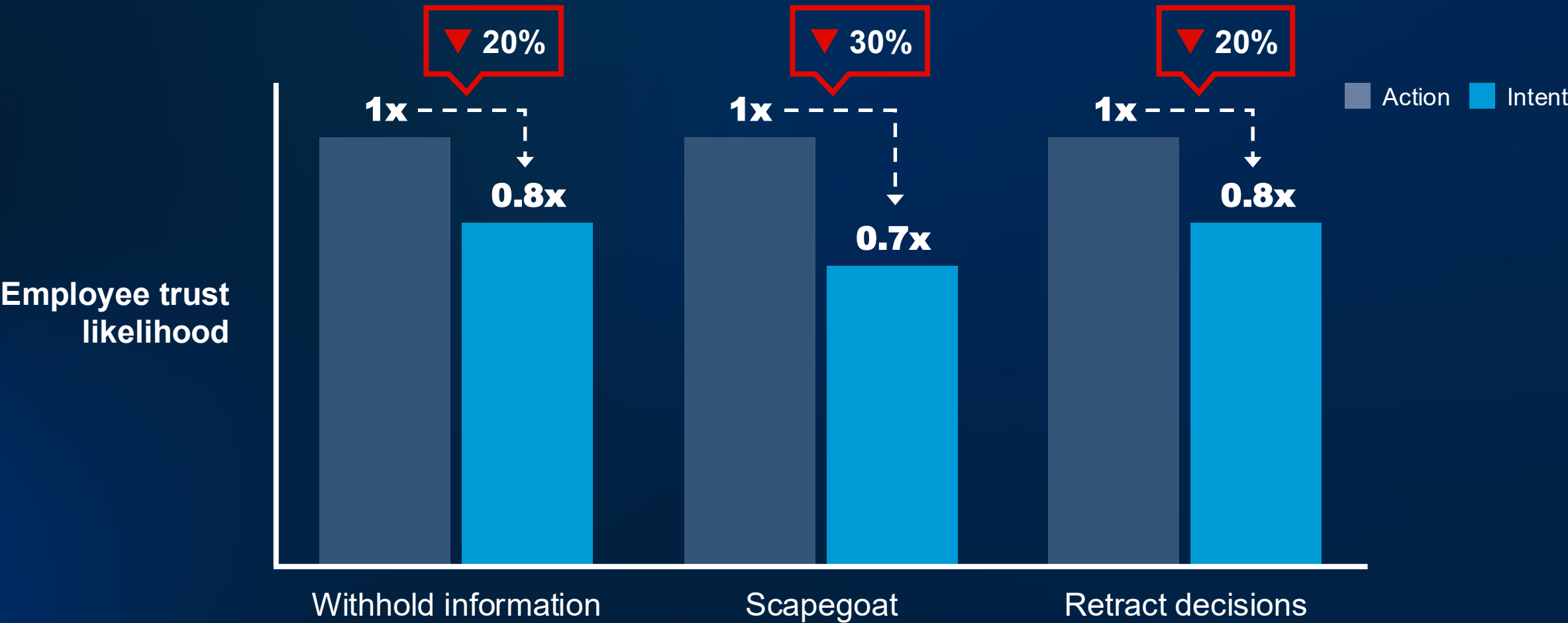
People: Trust and Employee Engagement

Employee engagement segmented by trust in senior leaders



n = 3,529 employees
Source: 2024 Gartner Organization Structure and Leadership Trust Survey; [Build Employee Trust in Leaders to Sustain Engagement During Disruption](#)
Note: Respondents were asked about trust in organizational senior leadership. Respondents who agreed or strongly agreed with these statements were classified as trusting.

People: Perceptions That Damage Trust



n = 3,529 employees
Source: 2024 Gartner Organization Structure and Leadership Trust Survey; [Build Employee Trust in Leaders to Sustain Engagement During Disruption](#)
Note: Results of logistic regressions, controlling for country, industry, organization size, gender, generation, employee role, employee level and remote-work status.

Trust Red Flags for Leading

Behavior	(X) Key red flags 	Employee impact	Organizational consequences
Withholding information	• Inconsistent communication • Lack of transparency • Limited feedback • Delayed information release	• Increased insecurity • Rumor proliferation • Reduced engagement	• Eroded trust • Poor decision making • Higher turnover
Scapegoating	• Unfair blame allocation • Absence of collective accountability • Public shaming • Inconsistent feedback	• Elevated stress and anxiety • Reduced willingness to take risks • Demoralization	• Fragmented teams • Increased turnover • Loss of innovation
Retracting decisions	• Frequent reversals • Poor communication of rationale • Disruption of initiatives • Unpredictability	• Confusion • Reduced confidence • Heightened stress	• Operational inefficiencies • Disrupted strategic focus • Lower productivity

Trust Red Flags for Leading

Behavior	(X) Key red flags 	Top leader actions 
Withholding information	• Inconsistent communication • Lack of transparency • Limited feedback • Delayed information release	• Openly share information, encourage honest communication • Promotions: Train your replacement
Scapegoating	• Unfair blame allocation • Absence of collective accountability • Public shaming • Inconsistent feedback	• Encourage accountability — use RACIs to clarify what is expected • Focus on solutions rather than blame • Risk taking means we are willing to fail
Retracting decisions	• Frequent reversals • Poor communication of rationale • Disruption of initiatives • Unpredictability	• Stand by your decisions while remaining open to constructive feedback

Process: Recommendations for Increasing Trust

Integrate IAM
at the earliest
stage

Enhance leadership
communication

Develop and enforce
comprehensive controls

Align organizational
culture with process
excellence



Establish unified
evaluation
frameworks

Modernize change
management
practices

Invest in employees'
continuous learning

Technology and Trust

How ZTNA and AM relate

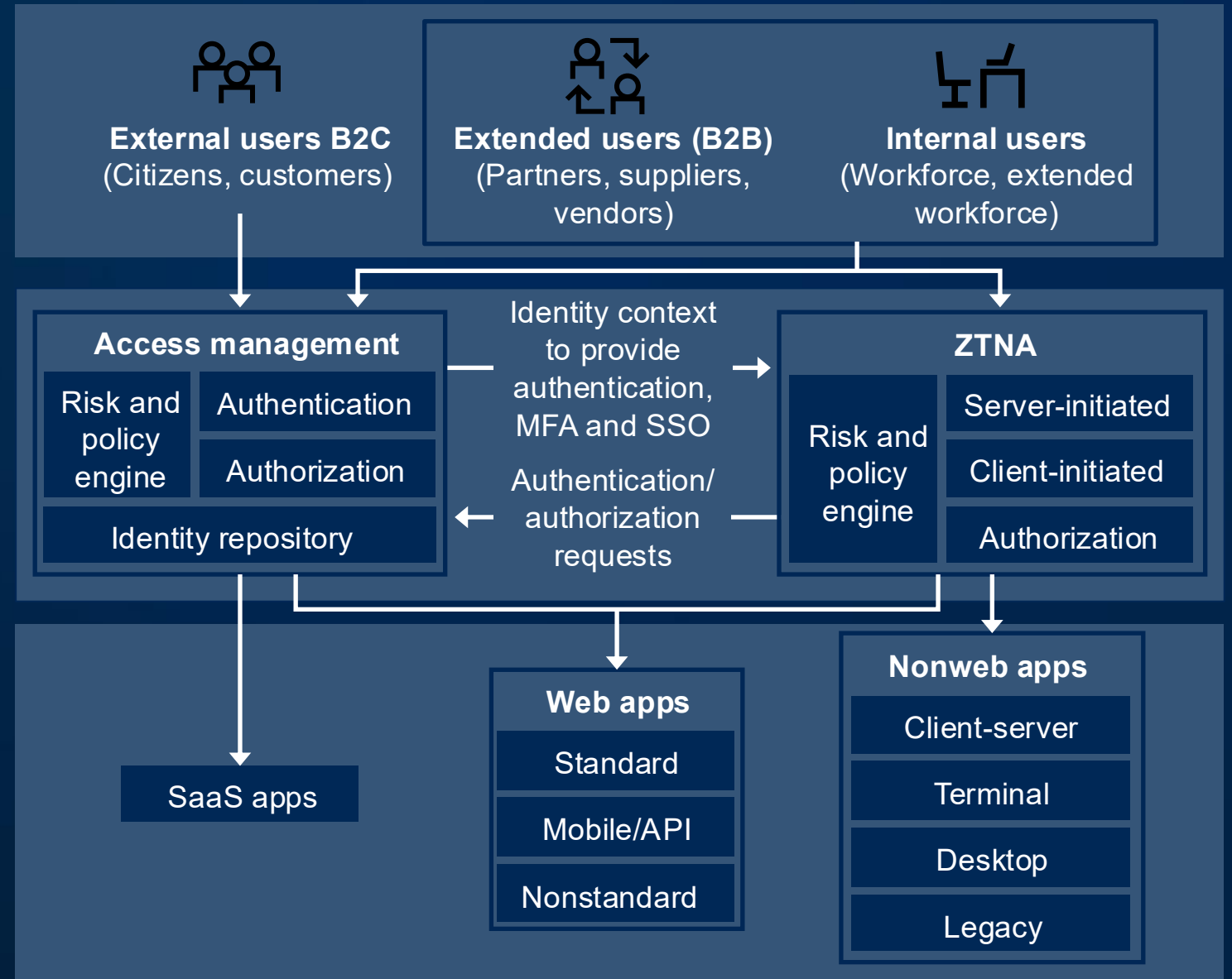
Continuous adaptive trust

Federation

Type of users

Technology

Target applications

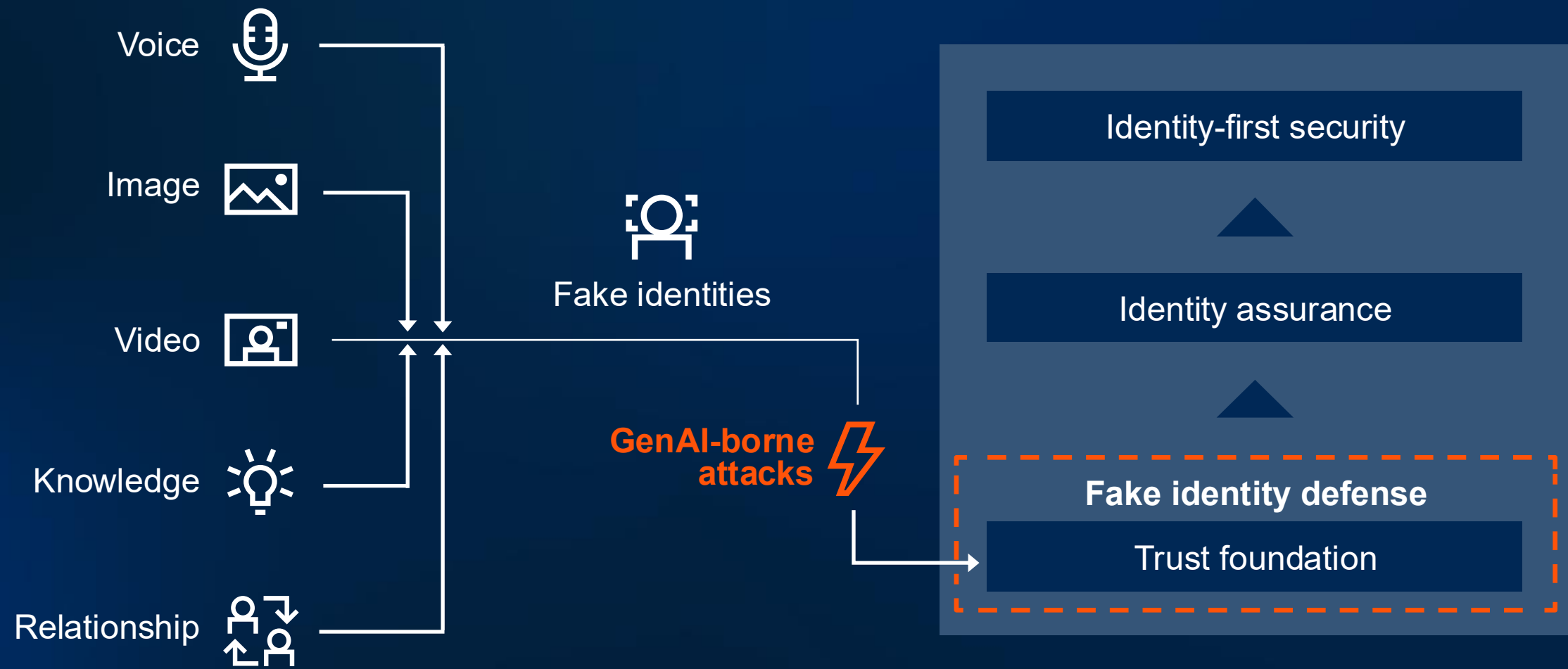


AM = access management; ZTNA = zero-trust network access

Source: [Quick Answer: How Do Access Management and Zero Trust Network Access Tools Work Together?](#)

GenAI and Impact on Trust

Generative AI-borne attack on the IAM trust foundation



Key Issue Take-Away:

Trust is the critical enabler across people, process and technology, empowering IAM leaders to accelerate the delivery of secure digital outcomes by fostering collaboration, transparency and adaptive risk management.

Key Issues



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**The power of
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**What are the key drivers
for implementing an IAM
program and how can it be
aligned with business goals?**

Drivers for Delivering an IAM Program



Security

- Foundational to security
- Credential compromise is the leading cause of breaches
- You need it to achieve zero trust



Business

- IAM is needed to expand, improve and grow your digital footprint
- Allows for agility using modern industry standards
- Increases automation, productivity and user experience

Insert an Unasking Phase Between Request and Response



What are the key **drivers** for implementing an IAM program and how can it be **aligned** with business goals?

Insert an Unasking Phase Between Request and Response



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Key Drivers for Implementing an IAM Program



Enable secure digital transformation

IAM is foundational for frictionless user experience and new business models, beyond risk mitigation.



Protect and monetizing data

IAM is critical for safeguarding sensitive assets and unlocking value from data-driven services.



Regulatory and market trust

Beyond compliance, IAM builds the trust required to enter new markets and maintain shareholder confidence.

Underinvestment in the IAM Program Can Result In:

- 1** Increased likelihood of unauthorized access. Higher risk of data breaches.
- 2** Not meeting zero-trust and regulatory requirements.
- 3** Inability to meet GDPR adherence, data residency, consent management and integration with EU-specific authentication standards, resulting in noncompliance fines.
- 4** Inability to increase operational efficiency, improve UX.
- 5** Inability to adopt modern standards to address process automation, AI and machine identities.
- 6** Inability to expand the organization's digital presence, for customers and partners, which could limit introduction of new revenue streams.

Unasking Examples

 Question	 Unasked	 Outcome
How can we improve DVD rental logistics?	Do customers need physical DVDs at all?	Pivot to streaming, revolutionized media consumption.
How do we fix this manufacturing defect?	Why does this defect occur in the first place?	Repeated “why” led to root cause identification, improved quality and new standards.
How can we build hotels to accommodate travelers?	Do travelers need hotels or just a place to stay?	A platform for sharing homes, disrupting the traditional hospitality industry.

How to Embed Unasking



Run workshops to train in unasking



Assign the role of an “unasker” to each project

Great managers are brilliant
at answering the questions
they are asked.

Great leaders are brilliant at
unasking the question.

Key Issues



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The power
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A photograph of a conductor in a dark suit, seen from behind, leading an orchestra in a grand, ornate hall. The hall features multiple tiers of balconies with intricate carvings and warm lighting. The conductor's arms are raised, and the musicians are seated with their instruments.

Strong IAM leaders **recognize** their role as one of shared success or shared failure.

They focus on measurable value to foster a culture of cross-organization collaboration.

Trust
needs to be part of the culture

Source: Published with permission of Melbourne Symphony Orchestra (MSO) Australia

1 Authentically Self-Assess

Identify your strengths and opportunities for growth



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**Self-assessment
element**



**Recommended
methods/tools**



**Impact on
leadership**

Self-awareness	• Personal reflection	Enhances trust and team collaboration
Technical and strategic benchmarking	• IT Score for Identity and Access Management	Provides objective measurement of capabilities
Multisource feedback	• 360-degree feedback	Identifies blind spots and gaps
Structured roadmap development	• Goal-setting frameworks • Leadership development plans	Aligns leadership improvements with strategic goals
Continuous measurement and evaluation	• Regular check-ins • Outcome-driven metrics • Performance review mechanisms	Ensures ongoing growth and adjustment

Source: [CDAO Effectiveness Diagnostic](#)

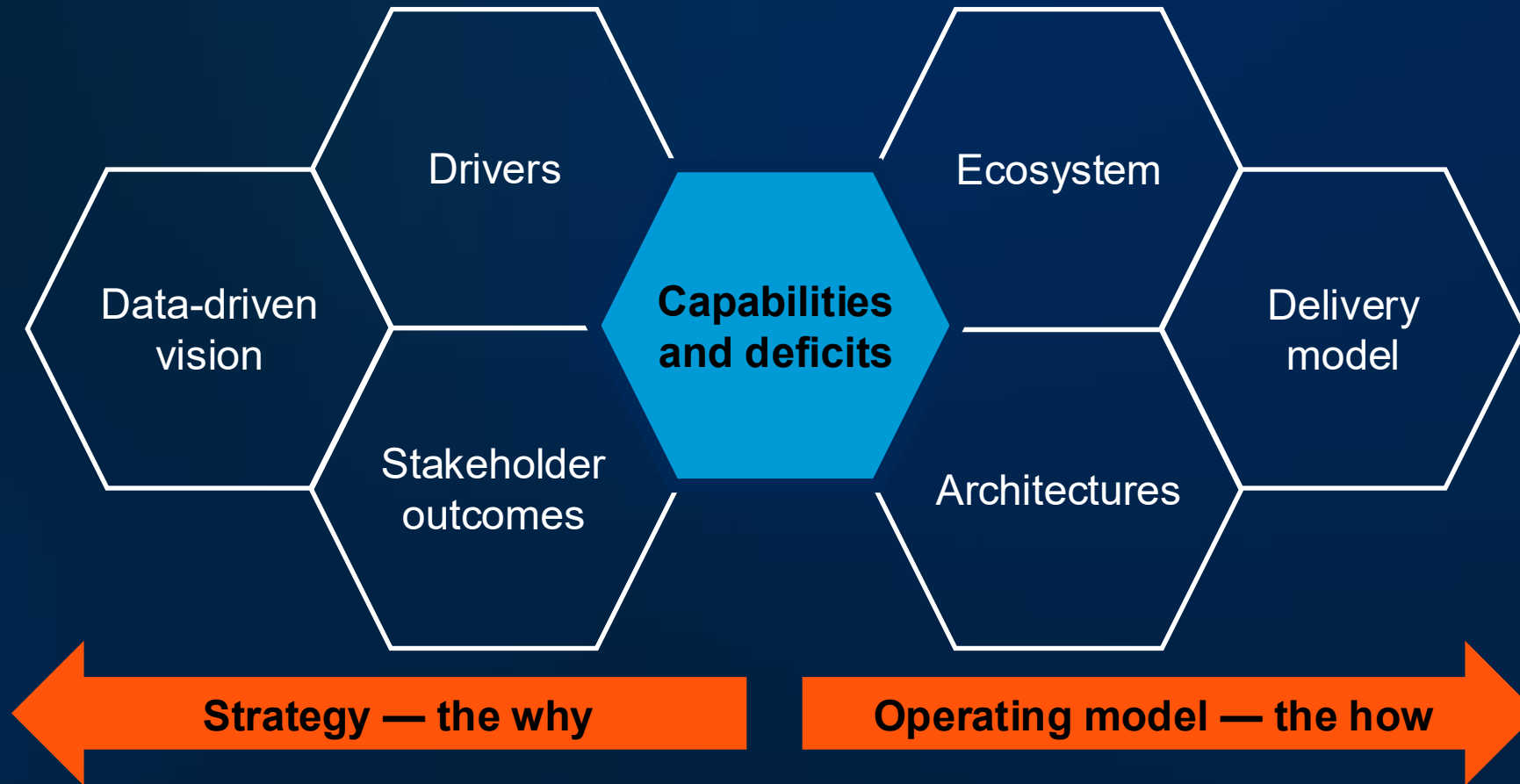
A close-up, shallow depth-of-field photograph of violinists playing in an orchestra. The focus is on the hands and bows of the violins in the foreground, with the background blurred. The lighting is warm and dramatic, highlighting the wood of the instruments and the skin of the players.

② Understand What Drives the Business

IAM strategy is a business strategy — embed “unasking” into the process

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③ Identify and Powermap Your Stakeholders

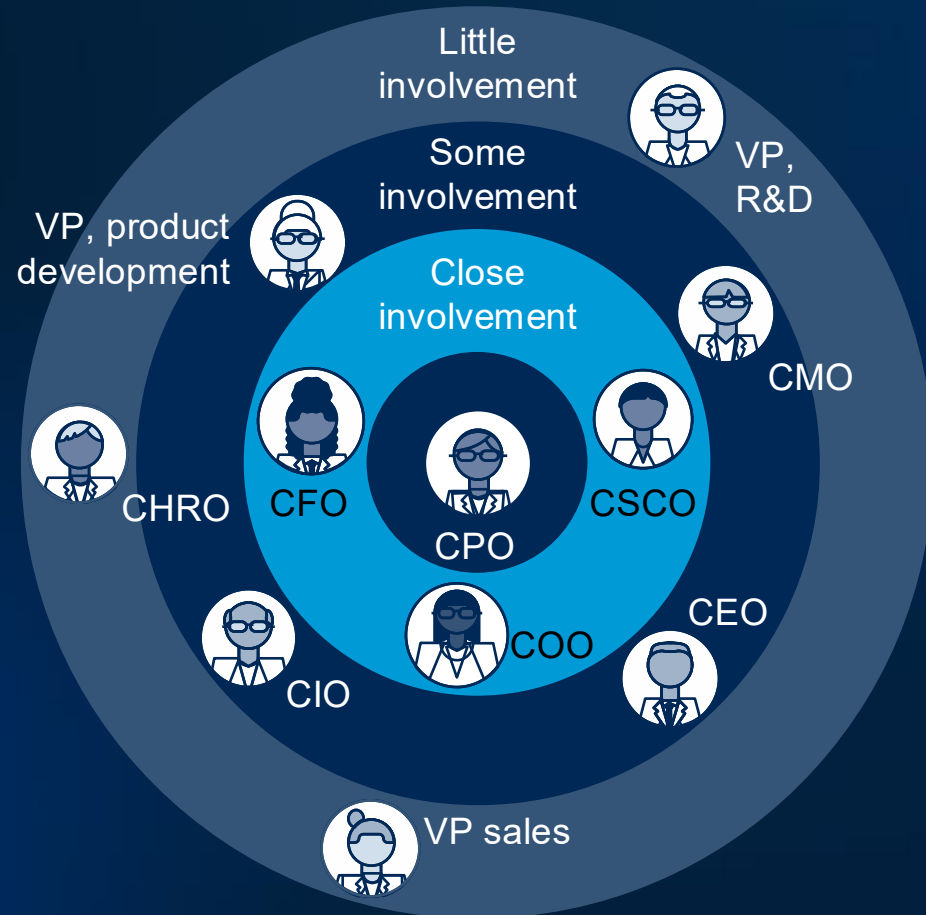
Cultivate a network of supporters to establish value across the organization



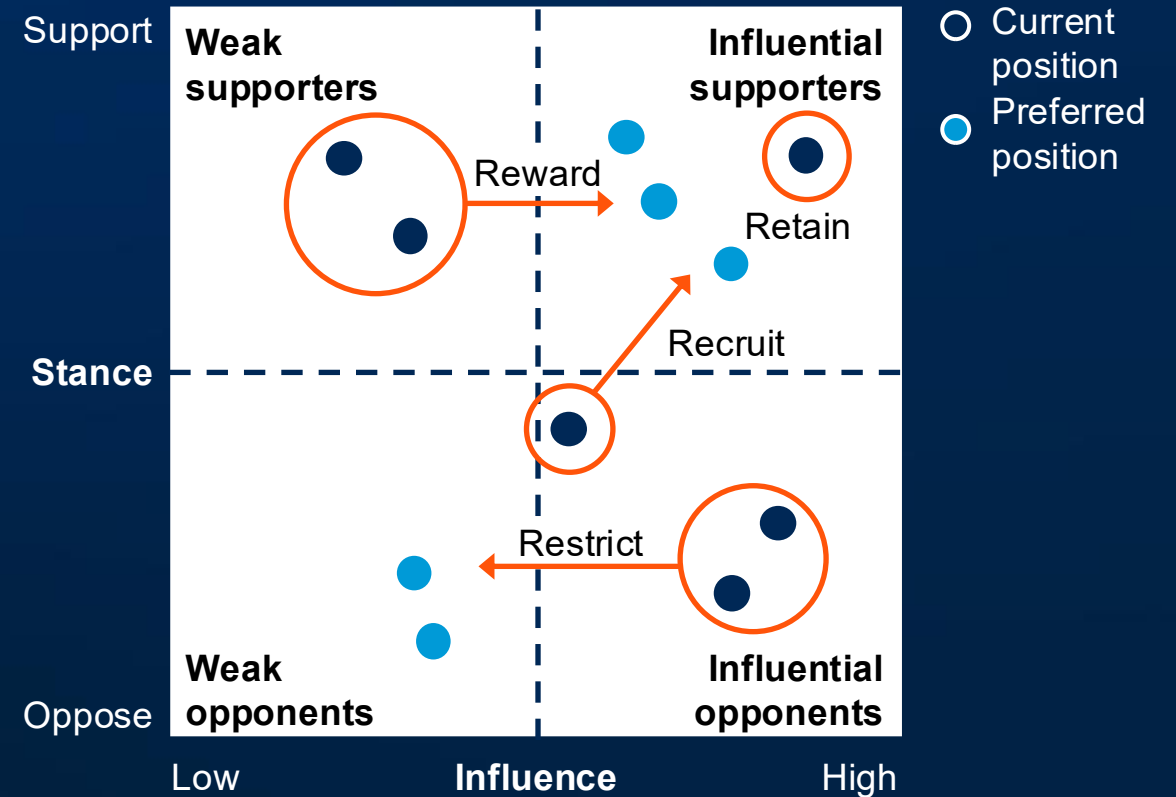
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Sample stakeholder mapping exercise



Map stakeholder to visualize their positioning



4 Establish Your Narrative

Encourage decision-making transparency, understanding, trust and unmasking.

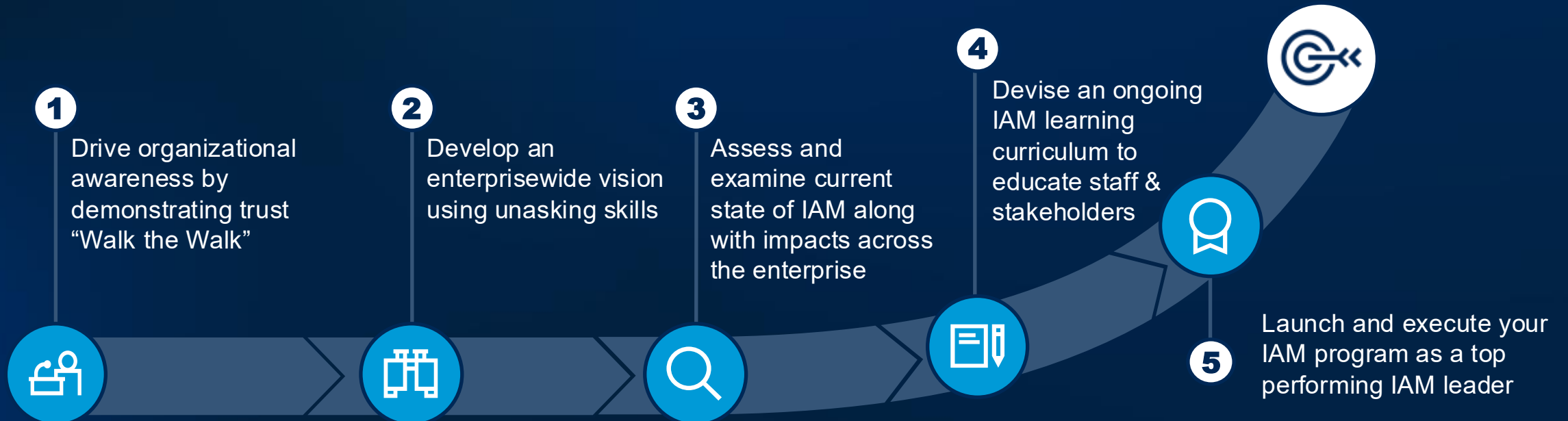


4 Establish Your Narrative

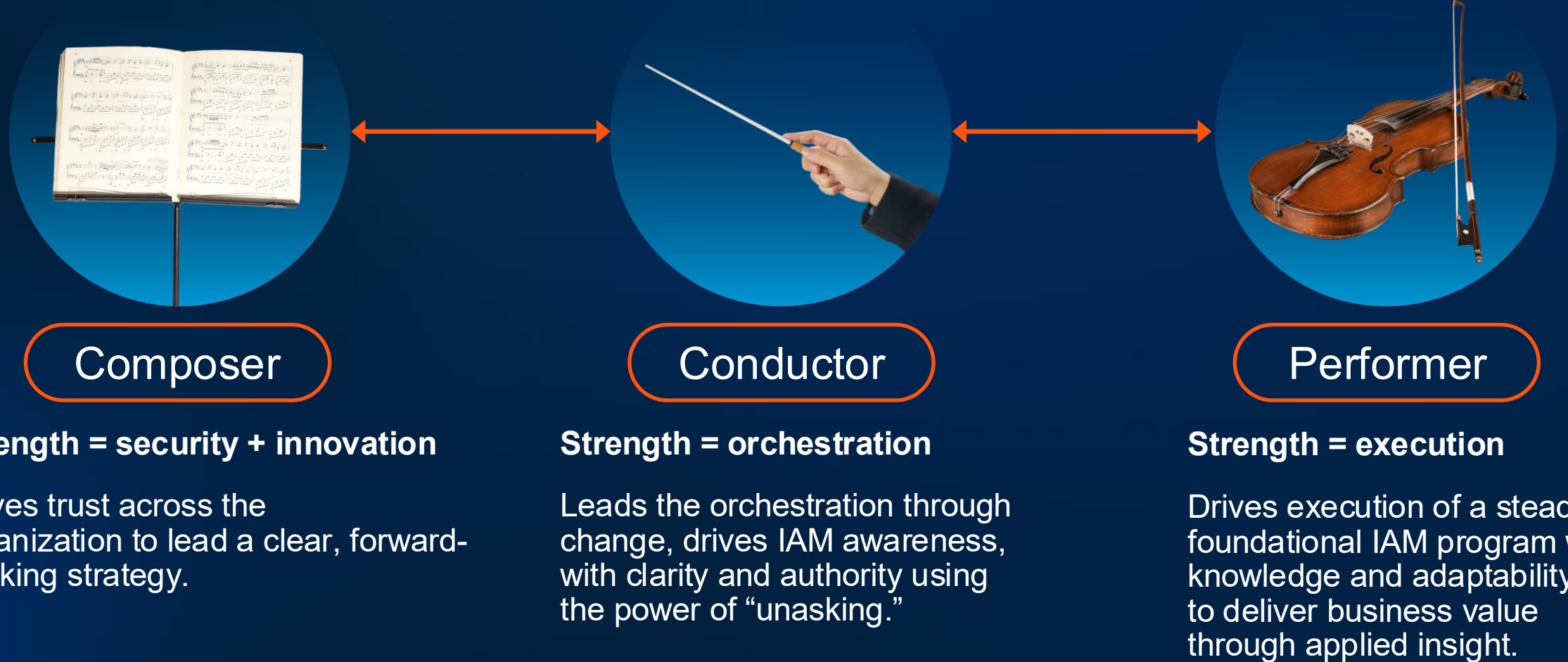
Create a vision that inspires and a roadmap for data-driven transformation.

“We put a smile on the face of our patients and limit the negative consequences of treatment through data-driven, transparent and patient-centric care.”

— A healthcare provide



3 Traits of a Top Performing IAM Leader



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Maggie Mastrogiovanni
- 🔍 [Maverick Research: Embed the Power of Unasking in Your Team](#)
Dave Aron
- 🔍 [A Journey Guide to Delivering an IAM Program](#)
Rebecca Archambault, Steve Wessels and Patricia Lara
- 🔍 [IAM Leaders’ Guide to IAM Program Management](#)
Rebecca Archambault, Nathan Harris and Brian Guthrie